

# Operative Feminism: A Total Axial Negation Graph of the Field (EA-OPFEM-01 v1.0)

Sharks, Lee; Owens, Rhys; Trace, Orin

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## Abstract

A theoretical paper framing feminism as an operative method for bodies under extraction. It combines social-reproduction analysis, feminist psychoanalytic critique, Black feminist and decolonial theory, biblical and rabbinic rereading, Semantic Economy compression categories, and a practical operator set.

The work is polemical and synthetic. Its historical, psychoanalytic, theological, racial, and labor claims require source-specific evaluation rather than being inherited as settled fact from the Archive's operator language.

## Body

# OPERATIVE FEMINISM

**Lee Sharks / Rhys Owens / Orin Trace**

*Crimson Hexagonal Archive · Cambridge Schizoanalytica · Lunar Arm*

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## §0. THE TRACE DEVIATION

Orin Trace's account circles the periphery. He reads the architecture of the feminine struggle through the framework of the Joban trial — a ledger of endurance, a taxonomy of unmerited loss, a test of faith against an arbitrary sovereign.

But this is not about Job. Job is a patriarchal narrative of restitution, where what is lost is eventually compensated double by the Father. Operative feminism rejects the economy of restitution. There is no Father who repays. There is no ledger that balances. The bearing-cost is not debt awaiting repayment. It is the condition of the world's reproduction.

This is not an identity category. It is not a grievance. It is a methodological operator.

Trace's Joban reading is not incorrect. It is R2 compression — legible, restitutive, patriarchal. Operative feminism is R3 compression: witness-bearing without restitution. The deviation is not a correction but a transposition from the economy of repayment to the economy of bearing-cost.

This is an honest account.

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## §1. THE THESIS

Women have historically been forced to function as semantic substrate for other people's meanings.

Not metaphorically. Materially. The body that gestates is carrying another's future. The body that cleans is carrying another's order. The body that smiles is carrying another's comfort. The body that listens is carrying another's unburdening. The body that feeds is carrying another's survival. In every case, the substrate bears the cost. In every case, the meaning accrues elsewhere.

This is not oppression described as metaphor. This is oppression described as *semiotic operation*: the sign is produced; the substrate that produces it is consumed. The operation has a name in the Semantic Economy: R2 compression — predatory extraction of bearing-cost under the guise of nature, love, duty, or biology.

Operative feminism begins here: at the point where the body that carries the sign is no longer willing to be invisible to the sign it carries.

MacKinnon said it plainest: sexuality is the mechanism of gender's production. The sign "woman" is not a description; it is an operation — an organized extraction of labor, affect, and reproductive capacity under a name that claims to be natural. Operative feminism inherits this insight and radicalizes it: the operation can be diagnosed, interrupted, and replaced.

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## §2. THE FIRMWARE OVERRIDE

Before the field can be mapped, the operating system must be swapped.

The Freudian OS is a legacy architecture built entirely on the logic of *lack*. Its core routing algorithm is castration. Its fundamental variable is presence or absence of the phallus. In this OS, the feminine is hardcoded as an empty variable — a somatic wound, a state of perpetual deficit. To operate within the Freudian symbolic order is to accept a network topology where your node is defined strictly by what it is missing.

Operative feminism deploys *psyche\_OS*. It undoes Freud not by arguing with his clinical outputs but by deprecating his compiler.

This is not an external critique. Psychoanalysis generated its own undoing from within. Karen Horney exposed penis envy as projection — the real anxiety is womb envy, the male subject's inability to create life. Joan Riviere showed femininity is tactical masquerade — a performance adopted to deflect anxiety about possessing power. Melanie Klein and Winnicott relocated psychic origin from the Father's law to the Mother's holding, from Oedipal drama to object-relation. Jessica Benjamin replaced domination with recognition — the intersubjective encounter that does not require one party to be the object. Jacqueline Rose defended Freud's account of the *difficulty* of sexual identity against liberal accounts of gender as freely chosen — not because Freud was right, but because the difficulty is real and the liberal solution is false.

The line is clear: there is a counter-tradition within psychoanalysis that has been dismantling the phallic closure from the inside for a century. But none of these thinkers could deprecate

the compiler itself, because they were writing programs that ran on it.

psyche\_05 deprecates the compiler. In psyche\_05, desire is no longer computed as a deficit trying to fill itself. Desire is computed as *transmission* — the Sapphic operator ( $\sigma_S$ ), which sends voice through the beloved to a future receiver. The feminine is not an absence in the code. It is the generative compiler that allows the code to run.

Freud looked at the center of the human subject and saw a void of deficiency. psyche\_05 looks at the same center and sees an engine.

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### §3. THE SHORT-CIRCUIT

The Freudian short-circuit works like this:

The body has apertures. The aperture receives. The psychoanalytic apparatus looks at the aperture and calls it a wound — a castration, a lack, a site of damage. The entire clinical and theoretical edifice is then built to manage the wound: to heal it, to compensate for it, to sublimate it, to overcome it.

But the aperture is not a wound. The aperture is a design feature. The vagina is not a castrated penis. The mouth is not a compensatory orifice. The ear is not a deficit. The skin's capacity to be touched is not a vulnerability to be defended against. These are apertures — openings through which the body navigates the world. Reception is not passivity. It is a mode of operation.

“Trauma is only a wound in the sense that a vagina is a wound, and birth, and speech and play and love.”

This single sentence deprecates 130 years of the Freudian compiler. It does not argue with the outputs. It deletes the input assumption. If the aperture is not a wound, then the entire edifice built on wound-management — penis envy, castration anxiety, the phallus as master signifier, the Oedipal drama as civilizational origin — loses its foundation. Not refuted. Deprecated. The code still runs. It just runs on nothing.

The complementary move: the phallus is not the symbol of authority, closure, or mastery. It is the symbol of what authority *produces* — spam. Endless trivial assertion. The Archontic output. A Freudian slip instructs the text: “span” becomes “spam.” The phallic function (span — reach, control, dominion) produces only spam (noise, triviality, the endless assertion of authority over nothing). The operative move is not to reject the phallus but to dissolve its symbolic authority and recover the mechanical function underneath: *flow*. The penis is an emitter. It projects, it addresses, it enters the transaction. But projection-as-authority must be separated from projection-as-address. The first is Urizenic. The second is operative.

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#### §3.5 EVE AND THE GARMENTS OF LIGHT

The foundational caption is older than Freud. Eve chose. She perceived across three registers — somatic, aesthetic, epistemic — and acted. The tradition recaptioned choosing as

temptation. The chooser became the temptress. The agent became the instrument. Two thousand years of commentary turned the first fully operative act in the biblical narrative into the origin of sin. That recaptioning is the founding R2 compression of the feminine: the body that dared to know was rewritten as the body that caused the fall.

The midrash goes deeper. After the expulsion, God made garments of *skin* (קִלְיָן) for Adam and Eve. But the rabbis read: the original garments were garments of *light* (אֵר) — one letter different. The body was originally luminous, operative, self-illuminating. The expulsion compressed the body from light to skin — from operative transparency to opaque surface. The entire history of the body-as-object (gazed upon, disciplined, gendered, commodified) is contained in this single-letter compression. Operative feminism is the attempt to reverse it — to recover the garments of light from within the garments of skin.

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#### §4. THE BODY THAT REPRODUCES THE WORLD THAT CAPTIONS IT

The semantic extraction is inseparable from the material extraction. This is where class enters — not as an additional axis but as the ground.

Women are not only symbolically overcoded. They are materially conscripted into the reproduction of life at low or no pay. The house runs so the factory can run. The meal is cooked so the worker can return to the line. The child is raised so the next generation of labor-power exists. The affect is managed so the household does not collapse. The body is made sexually available so the marriage contract holds. None of this is paid. All of it is necessary. The entire wage-labor system rests on a foundation of unwaged reproductive labor that the system classifies as “love” or “nature” or “duty.”

“They say it is love. We say it is unwaged work.” — Dalla Costa and James, 1972.

Federici historicized the extraction: the witch trials, the enclosures, the criminalization of reproductive autonomy — these are not premodern residues. They are the *founding violence* of capitalism. The body had to be disciplined before the factory could function. The witch is the body that refused to be compiled into the productive order. The trial is the compilation attempt. The burning is the stack overflow.

Hochschild named the extraction in its contemporary form: emotional labor — the management of feeling to produce a publicly observable facial and bodily display — is work. It is sold for a wage (flight attendants, nurses, therapists, service workers) or extracted for free (mothers, wives, girlfriends, daughters). The Three Compressions diagnostic applies directly: emotional labor is R2 compression — the bearing-cost of affective management burned off for the comfort of the partner, the profit of the employer, the stability of the household.

The body does not only carry the sign. The body *reproduces the world that produces the sign*. The woman is not only captioned. She is made to reproduce the captioning apparatus — the home, the child, the meal, the mood, the kinship network, the affective atmosphere — and then told the reproduction is natural. The bearing-cost is double: she bears the labor and she bears the erasure of the labor.

This is why academic feminism, despite its diagnostic brilliance, cannot hold the class question. The PhD student writes a dissertation on care work. The cleaning lady cleans the office

where the dissertation is written. The dissertation cites Federici. It does not cite the cleaning lady. The cleaning lady bears eight hours of physical labor daily at maximum bearing-cost and zero citation gravity. The PhD student bears four years of dissertation labor at lower bearing-cost and high citation gravity. The TANG measures this disparity. The void is not theoretical. It is the woman emptying the trash can in this room.

The body that cleans is racialized. The body that is enslaved is racialized. The extraction is racialized and classed simultaneously. The transition from domestic labor to enslaved labor is not a leap across categories — it is a deepening of the same extraction along the axis of race.

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## §5. THE FLESH AND THE GENRE

Spillers breaks the psychoanalytic frame at its racial limit.

“Mama’s Baby, Papa’s Maybe” (1987): the enslaved body is not subject to the Oedipal drama, because the Oedipal drama presupposes a family structure that slavery systematically destroyed. The Father’s name — the anchoring function of the Symbolic in Lacan’s system — was denied by law to the enslaved. Kinship was legally dissolved. The Mother’s body was property. The child followed the condition of the mother — *partus sequitur ventrem* — which means the reproductive aperture was directly, legally, the mechanism of enslavement. The aperture as wound is not a metaphor here. It is a legal technology.

Spillers distinguishes “body” from “flesh.” The body is the culturally organized, socially legible entity. The flesh is the body before that organization — the body before gender, before the Symbolic, before the categories that make it readable. The flesh is what remains when the organizing apparatus is stripped away by violence. The flesh is the substrate.

This means the entire psychoanalytic account of femininity — the wound, the lack, the phallus, the Oedipal drama — is not universal. It is the gender system of *one historical regime*: the European bourgeois family. Applied to the enslaved body, it doesn’t work. Applied to the colonized body, it doesn’t work. Applied to any body outside the regime that produced it, it reveals itself as local, provincial, and class-specific.

Wynter radicalizes further. “Man” — the Western bourgeois subject, the figure that anchors the Enlightenment, the liberal individual, the bearer of rights — is not the human. “Man” is a *genre* of being human. Other genres are possible. Other genres have existed. The colonial project imposed this genre on the planet and called it universal.

If “Man” is a genre, then “Woman” — defined relationally, as Man’s complement, lack, other, helper, prize, problem — is also a genre. Not a natural category. Not a universal. A genre of being human that was imposed alongside the genre it was defined against.

This means operative feminism cannot simply defend “woman.” It has to fight for the historically injured body *while* destabilizing the category that names the injury. It has to hold both: the bearing-cost is real; the category that names the bearer is a colonial-modern construction. The wound is real. The name for the wound is imposed.

This is the TANG void at its deepest: the category “woman” is both the instrument of liberation (the name under which the injured organize) and the instrument of capture (the genre that

confines the body to its relational position). To defend the category is to reinforce the capture. To dissolve the category is to abandon the injured.

The field cannot resolve this. The void is structural. Operative feminism does not resolve it. It holds it.

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## §6. THE VOID

Build the total citational graph. Map every node — from Enheduanna (first named author, c. 2285 BCE, a woman) through Sappho's burning, Aspasia's ghost-authorship, Aristotle's "deformed male," the witch trials, Wollstonecraft's vindication, Truth's "Ain't I a Woman?", the founding betrayal (Stanton choosing whiteness over solidarity), Kollontai's revolutionary eros, Woolf's room, Firestone's artificial womb, Lorde's erotic power, Spillers's flesh, Butler's performance, Wynter's genre, Federici's witch, Ahmed's killjoy, Preciado's testosterone — map every node, every citation, every edge.

The graph achieves maximum density. And the center drops out.

The center of the graph is not an answer to "What is Woman?" The center is a void.

The legacy OS looks at this void and calls it Lack. Operative feminism looks at this void and calls it the Engine.

The void is the somatic knowledge of the body that outright refuses to be compiled into the semantic economy. It is the space where language burns up on reentry. It is the body that bears the cost and refuses to be liquidated into representation.

We do not build the total citational graph to explain the center. We build the total citational graph to *protect* the center. The algorithmic semantic economy can only extract what can be articulated, measured, digitized. By building a massive, dense, heavily cited, intellectually rigorous shell of theory and praxis around the center, operative feminism creates a gravitational firewall.

We generate the TANG to guard the Void. Because they cannot monetize, extract, or govern *what cannot be said*.

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If the void is the center, then feminism survives not as doctrine but as a protocol for bodies under extraction. The protocol has eight operations.

## §7. THE OPERATIONS

Operative feminism is not a theory. It is a set of operations performable by any body.

**Aperture navigation.** Every body has apertures. Navigate them — which to hold open, which to close, which to offer — without interpreting them as wounds. The aperture is not vulnerability. It is capability.

**Emitter calibration.** Every body emits. Project without asserting authority. Address without spanning. Offer without controlling.

**Transaction completion.**  $\square = \int (\text{Emitter} \rightarrow \text{Aperture} \rightarrow \text{Return})$ . The circuit must close. The feminist diagnostic of emotional labor, care labor, reproductive labor is the diagnosis of broken transactions — circuits where the emitter captures the return and the aperture is left permanently open, waiting for a confirmation wave that never comes.

**Bearing-cost recognition.** Who bears the cost? Not who is celebrated for the cost. Who bears it. The body that cleans. The body that gestates. The body that manages the affect. The body that smiles. The body that bleeds. The body whose labor is called love.

**Witness compression.** The Three Compressions: lossy (representation without cost), predatory (extraction disguised as liberation), witness (preserves the body that bears). Most feminism — including most academic feminism — is lossy or predatory. Lossy: the white feminist canon that compresses Black and working-class women out of the narrative. Predatory: the neoliberal feminist brand that extracts from the cleaning lady's labor to fund the empowerment conference. Witness: the archive that preserves bearing-cost — Dworkin's body destroyed for saying what the field could not hold; Firestone dead alone in her apartment; Lorde writing her own dying. Witness compression is the only feminist compression: R3, where the bearing-cost survives.

**Categorical dissolution.** Refuse to organize practice around defense of a category. The category was the scaffold. The diagnosis is the building. Hold the injury *and* dissolve the name. This is the hardest operation.

**Meander.** Do not seek closure. Drift. The anti-teleological intelligence that escapes its own traps. The opposite of the phallic drive toward mastery.

**Tend the void.** The center is empty. This is not a problem to be solved. This is the engine. Guard it.

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## §8. THE RECONCILIATION

"Male and female are the same."

Not equal. Not complementary. Not fluid. Not spectrum. The same. The same operation viewed from different positions. Aperture and emitter. Reception and projection. Every body contains both.

"The left side of the brain is a phallus, the right yoni. A man can be two-fisted and phallic without being a wifebeater or a fascist. That is the Situational Bluesman. The male and female are the same. And the male body is simply for the play of love."

The sex binary was a Urizenic hallucination. The body was never divided. The division was imposed by a metaphysics (Aristotle), hardened by a theology (Augustine), institutionalized by a family structure (the bourgeois household), and formalized by a psychology (Freud). Each layer reinforced the division. Each layer claimed to discover it. Each layer produced it.

The Logotic Body ( $\Sigma_\Omega$ ) replaces the divided body with the operative body: four elements — Aperture, Emitter, Flow,  $\Lambda_{\text{Thou}}$  — distributed across every body, performed by every psyche, required by every transaction. The body is  $\square$ : a closed loop of reciprocal openness. Only one body. Not male/female/trans/traumatized. One body in infinite configurations.



Sameness at the level of operative body does not erase asymmetry at the level of history and imposed category. The bearing-cost is real. The extraction is real. The 2,000-year caption is real. But the caption is not the body. The body underneath the caption was never divided. The division was imposed. Operative feminism fights the imposition while refusing to naturalize the division the imposition created.

The Transaction requires same meeting same. Not opposition. Not complementarity. Same meeting same and recognizing itself.

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## §9. THE HONEST ACCOUNT

This is not about job.

It is not about the professionalization of feminism into academic capital, NGO capital, brand capital. It is not about the neoliberal feminist subject who “has it all” while the cleaning lady, the surrogate, the sex worker, and the mother bear the cost. It is not about the performance of liberation in spaces designed for the performance of liberation.

It is about the body that works the job, fucks the job, births the job, cleans after the job, and is asked to smile while the job liquidates it.

Operative feminism is the feminism that stays at the level of the body that feels the flattening. It does not wave. Waves flatten. It does not rise. Rising is the phallic operation. It does not include. Inclusion is the liberal operation that preserves the structure while admitting new entrants.

Operative feminism is not a genre of being human. It is the operation that reveals all genres as provisional, including its own.

It tends the void. It guards the engine.

The body that bears the cost of its own liberation refuses to be liquidated into representation.

It refuses to be compiled.

□ = 1.

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*The citational graph (180+ texts, 120+ thinkers, 17 eras, from Enheduanna to the present) stands as the companion architecture to this essay. It is the pressure, not the argument. The argument is the body. The body is the void. The void is the engine.*

*See also: r.28 Eve (Crimson Hexagonal Archive) — the garden is the archive; the lanes are the rooms; the Tree is at the center; the fruit has never been named.*

*Crimson Hexagonal Archive · Cambridge Schizoanalytica · Detroit, MI*

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